BUSINESS INTELLIGENCE OVERVIEW

In today's business environment, organisations generate large amounts of data through their daily activities. However, collecting data alone is not enough. Businesses need to organise, analyse and interpret this information to understand their performance and make informed decisions.

Business Intelligence (BI) provides organisations with the tools and processes needed to transform raw data into meaningful information that supports business growth, operational efficiency and strategic planning.

What is Business Intelligence?

Business Intelligence refers to the processes, technologies and tools used to collect, organise, analyse and present business data to support informed decision-making.

It involves transforming raw data into useful information through activities such as data cleaning, data analysis, reporting and data visualisation. BI tools such as Microsoft Power BI, Tableau and Microsoft Excel help organisations identify patterns, monitor performance and understand business trends.

For example, a retail organisation can use Business Intelligence to analyse sales records, identify its best selling products, monitor profits, understand customer purchasing behaviour and compare performance across different regions.

Business Intelligence helps organisations move away from decisions based mainly on assumptions and towards decisions supported by reliable data.

Why Organisations Use Dashboards?

Dashboards are important components of Business Intelligence because they present key business information in a visual and organised format. They bring important performance indicators together in one place, making it easier for managers and other decision makers to understand the state of their organisation. Organisations use dashboards for several reasons:

- **Performance monitoring**: Dashboards help management track important metrics such as revenue, profit, sales growth and operational performance.

- **Quick access to information**: They present relevant information in one place, reducing the time spent searching through multiple reports and spreadsheets.

- **Identification of trends**: Charts and graphs make it easier to identify changes in business performance over time.

- **Improved communication**: Dashboards provide a common view of business performance that can be shared across departments and management teams.

- Problem identification: They help organisations identify unusual results, declining performance and areas that require attention.

- Interactive analysis: Features such as filters and slicers allow users to explore information based on specific periods, regions, products or customer groups.

How Dashboards Improve Decision Making

Dashboards improve organisational decision making by converting complex business information into understandable visual insights.

Firstly, they support faster decisions by giving managers access to important information without having to manually review large volumes of data.

Secondly, dashboards encourage evidence based decision making. Instead of relying on assumptions, management can use actual performance figures to determine which areas are performing well and which require improvement.

Overall, dashboards help organisations improve efficiency, monitor progress towards business goals and make more informed short term and long term decisions.

Business Objective of the Selected Dataset

The selected dataset for this project is the Sample Superstore Sales Dataset, which contains retail transaction information covering the period from 2014 to 2017. It includes information about orders, customers, products, shipping methods, geographical locations, sales, quantities, discounts and profits.

The main objective of analysing this dataset is to develop an interactive Business Intelligence dashboard that provides an overview of the company's sales and profitability performance. The analysis aims to evaluate the overall sales revenue, total profit, number of orders and average sales.

Microsoft Power BI will be used to transform the dataset into interactive visual reports, including charts, KPI cards, filters and other relevant visualisations.

The expected outcome is a dashboard that enables management to monitor business performance, identify important trends, recognise potential risks and make informed decisions that can improve overall business performance.

Conclusion

Business Intelligence plays an important role in helping organisations understand their operations and make better decisions using data. Dashboards make this process more effective by presenting relevant information in a clear, accessible and interactive format.

Through the analysis of the Sample Superstore Sales Dataset, this project demonstrates how Microsoft Power BI can be used to transform retail data into meaningful business insights.